

ABSENCE

Written by

Andrew Yan

FADE IN:

INT. LUXURIOUS MANSION - EVENING - PRESENT

A mansion too large for one man. Marble floors, tall windows, empty hallways, and a fireplace burning quietly.

DAN(31), yet pale and sharply dressed, sits alone, slumped on his couch, flames flickering across his face as he watches an old interview of a younger version(20s) of himself. Cleaner. Brighter. All before everything collapsed.

JOURNALIST (ON SCREEN)  
...When people talk about Pronto,  
they talk about the memories. They  
talk about the freedom. The talk  
about the places they've lost, the  
experiences they missed.

Dan stares blankly at the screen.

JOURNALIST (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)  
The people are incredibly lucky to  
have such a company. However, there  
is one answer that we are all  
desiring. What happened to Noah?

On the television, Dan freezes. In the mansion, Dan freezes along with him.

JOURNALIST (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)  
(persistent)  
What happened to Noah?

Dan reaches for the remote and pauses the interview. The fire becomes cold. The mansion becomes soulless. He sits in silence, staring blankly at his reflection on the screen.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - AFTERNOON - PAST

In the hospital room, DAN(20), significantly younger, sits on the bed, staring at the TV. An IV drip connects to his hand while he sits alone in the empty room, a blanket over his severed legs.

A KNOCK on the door. It opens. NOAH(19), Dan's best friend, walks in with a grin, holding two vending machine coffees and a folded piece of paper. Dan continues to stare at the TV.

NOAH

Hey.

Dan does not look away from the screen.

NOAH (CONT'D)

I brought the worst coffee here.

He sits down beside Dan.

NOAH (CONT'D)

The nurse said you were awake.

DAN

She talks too much.

A silence settles. Dan refuses to look at Noah.

NOAH

I'll be staying.

DAN

Noah.

NOAH

Danny.

DAN

Don't do this.

NOAH

Do what?

Noah stares at him. Dan takes his eyes off the wall.

DAN

Look.

(sits up)

Half of me is gone.

NOAH

Your legs. Not you.

Dan laughs. A forced, empty laugh.

NOAH (CONT'D)

I had an idea on the way here.

He unfolds the piece of paper.

DAN

Not now.

NOAH  
What if people could go anywhere?  
Not VR. Not the metaverse. It's  
their own world.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
Their own memories. A beach, for  
example. Or their childhood home.  
Or even someone they lost.

Dan looks at the paper.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
It's something that accesses their  
memory and projects it through  
sensory nerves. Directly onto the  
neurons of our brains. It's  
basically real.

Noah hands the paper to Dan. He flips it around. It's filled  
with scribbles and drawings of different models. Dan exhales.

DAN  
(shakes his head)  
I mean, this could--

NOAH  
It's the closest thing people can  
touch.

Dan puts down the paper.

DAN  
We have no money. No lab.

NOAH  
We don't need one yet.

Dan looks at Noah.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
We don't need one. One room. One  
computer. A memory at a time.

Dan looks back at his piece of paper. He stares at it.

DAN  
I can't even stand.

NOAH  
Then don't.

A silence. He looks at Noah again.

DAN  
We start small.

Noah smiles.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - DAY

A small office. A cheap reception desk, a weak coffee machine, and a banner taped to the wall that reads: PRONTO. Dan sits at the desk. Noah rearranges brochures behind him. A headband sits on a stand, enclosed in a glass box.

Noah picks up a letter on the reception desk. He reads it.

NOAH  
It says... you gave me the ten  
minutes I thought God had taken  
away.

Dan does not know what to say. He stares at the envelope.

DAN  
The sound still glitches.

NOAH  
It's enough.

MONTAGE - PRONTO GROWS

-- Customers enter the office, letters pile on top, one after another through multiple shots intertwined.

-- Hands shake Dan's.

-- People hug Noah.

-- A father cries in the lobby.

-- A child draws a picture of the machine.

-- Noah listens to every customer.

-- The office grows busier.

-- The letters begin to overtake Dan's desk.

END MONTAGE

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - NIGHT

Dan and Noah sit at their desks in the empty building, their letters piled on top of each other. Dan opens each one carefully, reading them, and putting them back. Noah tinkers with a prototype of a new device.

NOAH  
Hey. Sleep time when?

DAN  
I'm almost done.

Noah stares at a mountain of envelopes.

NOAH  
I've been figuring out this...  
thing. We can... interact with the  
past. Change it. Not just observe.

Dan does not respond. Under the quiet office roof, he continues reading each letter, storing them in a tiny box.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
So... you could've kept your legs.

Dan does not notice. He continues reading the letters. Noah looks at him. Moved.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - DAY

The office becomes larger, brighter, and alive with color. Screens glow. Customers wear thin neural bands over their temples. Noah pushes Dan's wheelchair through the crowd, past engineers, investors, assistants, and customers.

NOAH  
So... Finn wanted to make a call,  
and the hospital wanted three  
hundred copies, and... I rejected  
the military one.

DAN  
You said no?

NOAH  
You would've said no.

DAN  
Mm... I probably would've waited.

NOAH  
That's why I said no.

They pass by a room. A VOLUNTEER holds her hand out in front of her, reaching. Someone takes off her headband.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
She knows it's not real.

DAN  
Everyone does.

Noah looks at Dan, as if implying something.

DAN (CONT'D)  
It's too dangerous. We have no  
control over how much the prototype  
changes the world.

\*  
\*

NOAH  
It's revolutionary.

They look as the Volunteer laughs through tears.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
They want to change things.

DAN  
No.

Noah looks at him.

DAN (CONT'D)  
They want to go back. That's  
different.

NOAH  
Okay.

He doesn't sound convinced.

DAN  
Noah.  
(beat)  
Promise me. No time machines.

NOAH  
We have the technology already. All  
I need to do is to fix the arrival  
within the time period.

DAN  
We don't get to rearrange someone's  
grief just because they told us to.

NOAH  
You got your freedom back already.  
Now you'll get your life back.

DAN  
Too far. Please. What happened has  
happened already.

Noah walks away, leaving Dan behind, glancing as his  
silhouette disappears down the hall.

MONTAGE - BUILDING THE DREAM

-- Dan and Noah present together. They finish each other's  
sentences. The room listens attentively.

-- Dan pulls himself up on prosthetic legs in physical  
therapy. Noah watches from the doorway, silent and moved.

-- Noah tinkers with a device, Dan by his side, watching.

-- Dan gives his first interview. Off camera, he gestures for  
Noah to join him. Noah smiles and stays back.

END MONTAGE

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - NIGHT

In the empty office, Dan sits by himself under dim lights,  
watching a press conference of himself, nervous but sincere.  
Noah stands behind him, arms crossed.

DAN  
I hate my voice.

NOAH  
Everyone does.

Dan pauses the video. On the screen, he pauses mid sentence.

DAN  
You should've been there.

NOAH  
I was.

DAN  
You know what I mean.

He closes the laptop.

DAN (CONT'D)  
It was your idea.

NOAH  
It was our idea.

DAN  
Then why do you keep hiding?

NOAH  
Dan. Look at me.  
(beat)  
They believe you. All you have to  
do is talk.

DAN  
I'm not a poster. I need you.

NOAH  
Just standing beside you?

Dan looks at Noah.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
You're on your legs now. You're the  
proof that this works.

DAN  
I don't want to do this alone.

NOAH  
Dan.

DAN  
I mean it.

NOAH  
I know.

Noah's smile falters. That hurt more than expected.

NOAH (CONT'D)  
You don't need me in every room.

DAN  
Maybe I do.

Noah opens his mouth. He doesn't say anything.

NOAH  
Then maybe I'm doing something  
wrong.

He winces at his own words.

DAN  
What does that mean?

NOAH  
It means.  
(beat)  
It means, tomorrow, go alone.

Dan looks back at the interview.

DAN  
Leave.

NOAH  
You'll be okay.

DAN  
Leave.

Noah does not leave. He sits down in a chair beside Dan.

MONTAGE - CONTINUING THE DREAM

-- The company expands, but now the cuts are slower. Desks fill. Phones RING. Dan is pulled into meetings while Noah disappears into the lab.

-- Dan is being interviewed alone, again and again, the speed ramping up faster and faster until...

END MONTAGE

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. COURTROOM - DAY - PRESENT

Dan sits at the witness stand in a large, bright room seated full of journalists and a PROSECUTOR. The judge's hammer SLAMS down.

PROSECUTOR  
When was the last time you saw Noah Vine?

Dan says nothing.

PROSECUTOR (CONT'D)  
Noah Vine was your co-founder. Your friend. Do you have any recollection of what happened to him on June 24th?

DAN  
(quietly)  
No.

PROSECUTOR  
Since Noah Vine's disappearance,  
the value of Pronto has tripled.

DAN  
I was only trying to keep the  
business alive.

PROSECUTOR  
(shouts)  
Or trying to erase him entirely.

The Prosecutor looks at Dan. Dan avoids the stare.

PROSECUTOR (CONT'D)  
Did you attempt to murder Noah  
Vine?  
(beat)  
And did you do so because you  
believed his death would benefit  
the company financially?

The room falls silent. There is no answer.

INT. NOAH'S OFFICE - DAY - PAST

A warm light filters through the window, softly illuminating  
Noah's cluttered office full of scattered models.

A KNOCK.

DAN (O.S.)  
Noah?

No answer. The door opens. Dan looks around. No one. He  
exits, checks the nameplate, and reenters.

He calls him. No answer.

A note on the desk. Dan picks it up.

One word. Only one word, staring at him innocently: Goodbye.

He calls him again. His breathing changes.

DAN (CONT'D)  
(mutters)  
Pick up.

Nothing.

He folds the note into his hands, closes the door, and sits down. For a moment, he gazes far; far into the busy hallways of the building.

INT. NOAH'S OFFICE - THREE HOURS LATER

A DETECTIVE sits in Noah's seat. Dan sits at the opposite side of the table, as if interrogated before an executive.

DAN  
No media yet. He hates publicity.

The Detective nods.

DAN (CONT'D)  
Find him. Please. Find him.

The Detective picks up the note. Dan watches as the note slowly drifts down, disappearing into a plastic bag.

INT. OFFICE BUILDING - DAY - PRESENT

Dan enters the lobby, now larger than before, covered in marble walls with concrete ceilings. Expensive furniture. Quiet halls. A massive advertisement plays. PRONTO: THE FUTURE BELONGS TO YOU.

No more colored lines. No more customer letters. No more of the company that once was.

Dan enters. Slowly, with a cane in his hand, he walks to his office. A small room without a window. Gradually, he sits down, turning on his computer. ACCESS DENIED. He tries again.

ACCESS DENIED.

A KNOCK on the door. His ASSISTANT enters.

ASSISTANT  
The board finalized the transition.

DAN  
Transition.

ASSISTANT  
Your resignation as leadership becomes effective next year.

DAN  
Since when?

ASSISTANT  
Your attorneys approved the  
transaction.

DAN  
The company?

ASSISTANT  
Operations will continue normally.

Dan looks through the thin gap between the open door.

ASSISTANT (CONT'D)  
Also, the fire has been scheduled.

DAN  
For the house?

ASSISTANT  
As requested, sir.

Dan says nothing. Only nods. The Assistant leaves without closing the door. Dan gets up. Slowly, he walks out of the office, not packing his cardboard boxes, not glancing back.

INT. LUXURIOUS MANSION - AFTERNOON

Dan walks inside the mansion, ignoring his mailbox, now overflowed with letters. Closes the door. Walks through the grand hallway, past the expensive art, past the luxurious furniture, and sits down on his couch. The television is black. The fireplace waits.

He looks tired. He looks finished.

He takes out a headband from his bag. A neural band. A first generation model, worn at the edges. Their original hand drawn logo etched into the casing, long abandoned by the company. He runs his thumb over the button. Presses it.

The mansion disappears.

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - DAY - CONTINUOUS

Dan opens his eyes. Twenty years younger. He sits on the hospital bed. An IV drip connected to his hand. Legs underneath a blanket. Everything exactly how it was.

A KNOCK on the door. Dan looks toward it. The door opens. Noah walks in with a grin, holding two vending machine coffees and a folded piece of paper.

NOAH

Hey.

Dan stares at him. For the first time in ten years.

NOAH (CONT'D)

I brought the worst coffee here.

Noah walks toward the bed.

DAN

(solemn)

No.

Noah stops.

DAN (CONT'D)

(trembles)

You need to leave.

NOAH

Danny--

DAN

Don't call me that.

Noah lowers the coffees.

DAN (CONT'D)

Throw that paper away.

NOAH

What are you talking about?

DAN

There is no Pronto. No company.  
There is nothing.

Noah stares at him.

DAN (CONT'D)

Walk out of the room. Never see me.

(beat)

Go and be alive.

The fluorescent lights begin to flicker. Noah's body glitches. He gets up slowly and stands beside the door.

Suddenly, he sits down beside Dan, exactly like before.

NOAH

I had an idea on the way here.

DAN

No.

Noah unfolds the paper.

DAN (CONT'D)

Stop.

NOAH

What if people could go anywhere?

DAN

Please. One last time.

Dan reaches for the paper. His hand passes through it. Noah smiles sadly. The coffee falls to the floor. The lights begin to flicker. Dan's eyes glance up towards him.

DAN (CONT'D)

Noah.

Noah vanishes.

The hospital room remains. Dan sits alone, still reaching toward the space where Noah was.

The folded paper rests beside him. He picks it up carefully, holding it like an ancient remnant.

Slowly, he unfolds it. Blank.

DAN (CONT'D)

No.

The hospital walls begin to collapse.

DAN (CONT'D)

Noah.

He grips the paper tighter.

DAN (CONT'D)

Please.

INT. LUXURIOUS MANSION - AFTERNOON - PRESENT

Dan opens his eyes. He sits alone on the couch. The fireplace as cold as ever, the neural band resting on his temples.

In his hands, there is no paper. Only air. Dan keeps his hands closed around it anyway.

Silence. He stares into the fireplace. Minutes seem to pass. Beside him, a device labeled the "PROTOTYPE" waits. Dan looks at it. He closes his eyes. Then reaches for it.

DAN

Just once.

He opens the device. Warnings flash. ARCHIVED MEMORY. SOURCE INCOMPLETE. CHANGE MAY CAUSE WRONG CONSEQUENCES.

Dan presses continue. Nothing happens. He presses it again.

A phone VIBRATES faintly. Dan looks up. The sound is not coming from his phone. The BUZZING grows louder.

PRE-LAP: A PHONE VIBRATING.

INT. NOAH'S OFFICE - DAY - PAST

A phone VIBRATES across Noah's desk. It reads: MISSED CALL - DAN. ONE NEW VOICEMAIL. Noah walks in.

INTERCUT - PRESENT MANSION / PAST OFFICE:

Inside the mansion, smoke curls quietly along the ceilings. Flames start to grow behind Dan.

DAN

Noah.

Noah brings his phone to his ear.

EXT. LUXURIOUS MANSION - NIGHT - PRESENT

Smoke escapes through the windows. It drifts up into the sky, finally able to be free.

DAN (V.O.)

(melancholic)

I really wanted to see you again.

(beat)

You were the only part that was real. I thought if I did enough, it would end. Like some Disney story.

(beat)

But there is no end. Only absence. And I wanted you too much to survive it.

Back at the office, Noah looks at the phone.

Flames fill the windows. The mansion burns against the pitch black sky. There is no scream. No rescue.

DAN (V.O.)  
So go away. Leave. Leave like you  
never met me.  
(beat)  
Goodbye.

A phone hits the floor offscreen. A THUD.

FADE OUT.